Docket No. FHWA-2026-1090 · OMB Control No. 2125-0587 · FR Doc. 2026-20718, 91 FR 64735 (October 9, 2026)

Comment on the Travel Monitoring Analysis System (TMAS) information collection: rural road and nonmotorized coverage of count stations

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I submit this comment in my individual capacity as an independent researcher in transportation and regional planning. I do not represent any agency or organization. The comment draws on a technical report I prepared from public FHWA, Census, and FARS data: *How Well Do Federal Traffic Count Stations Cover Rural Roads? Evidence from the Travel Monitoring Analysis System, 2015–2024* (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23772244). The report's code and data are public.

1. I support extending the collection

The notice states that TMAS data will be used to "evaluate changes in vehicular and nonmotorized travel in order to assess impacts on highway safety." TMAS is the national compilation of states' continuous traffic counts, and it supports the travel estimates behind fatality rates. In response to the notice's first question, the collection is necessary, and I support its extension. My comments address the third question: how FHWA can improve the quality, usefulness, and clarity of the information collected. Each recommendation uses data FHWA already receives, so none should add meaningful burden for respondents (the second and fourth questions).

2. What the public TMAS data show about rural coverage

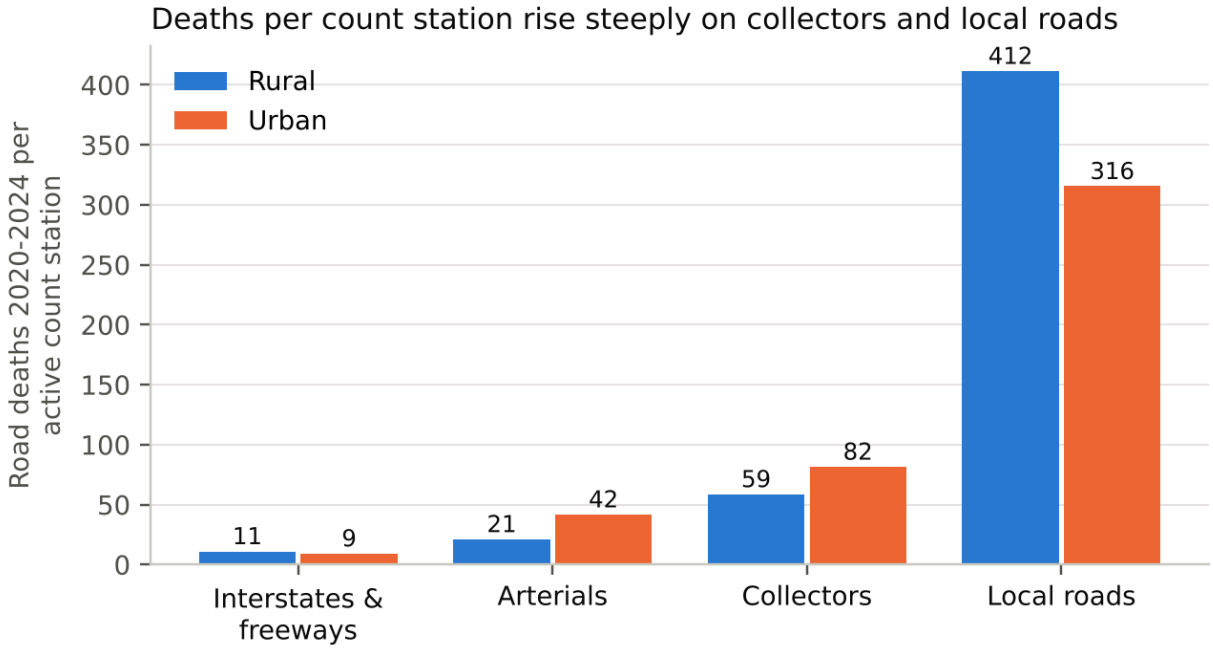
Using FHWA's 2024 TMAS station file and the twelve 2024 monthly volume files, I identified 7,859 stations that reported hourly volume in 2024. I compared them with Highway Statistics 2024 (Tables HM-20 and VM-2) and with FARS-based county death counts.

1. **Rural roads are covered in proportion to traffic, not mileage.** Rural roads have 48.9% of active stations, 31.1% of VMT, 70.3% of road miles, and 47.8% of 2024 road deaths. That is 3.75 stations per billion VMT (urban: 1.77) but only 1.30 stations per 1,000 miles (urban: 3.21).
2. **Rural collectors and local roads are almost unmonitored.** They are 91.1% of rural road miles and carry 34.0% of rural VMT. In 2020–2024, 39,758 people (40.5% of rural road deaths) died on them. They have 504 active stations (13.1% of rural stations). Rural local roads have 29 stations for 2.03

million miles, or 412 deaths per station, compared with 11 on rural interstates. Only 34 of 50 states have at least six active stations on these roads combined, the number the Traffic Monitoring Guide (TMG) recommends as a minimum for a single factor group.

3. **Many rural counties have no station at all.** 1,130 of 3,143 counties had no active station in 2024, including 46.6% of mostly rural counties. These counties recorded 23.4% of U.S. rural road deaths in 2020–2024.
4. **Growth has been mostly urban.** Between 2015 and 2024 the stations listed in TMAS grew 46% on urban roads and 20% on rural roads.
5. **Nonmotorized coverage cannot be assessed.** The public TMAS download contains no bicycle or pedestrian stations, even though TMAS accepts these data and the TMG nonmotorized station record already includes coordinates and an urban/rural field.

These figures do not show that rural traffic estimates are wrong. They show that, for most rural road mileage, TMAS offers little means to check them. The TMG's minimum volume factor groups (Table 3-1) combine all rural roads below the interstate into one "Other Rural" group. A state can meet that minimum with stations on rural arterials alone, and then apply their seasonal patterns to rural collectors and local roads.



Stations: TMAS 2024, FHWA rural/urban code. Deaths: Rural Road Fatality County Panel (Census 2020 urban areas).

Figure 1. Road deaths in 2020–2024 per TMAS station that reported volume in 2024, by road class. From the technical report (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23772244).

3. Recommendations

1. **Publish an annual coverage table.** With each year's TMAS release, FHWA could publish, by state, the number of stations that reported data, by functional system and rural/urban area, next to HM-20 mileage. This uses only data FHWA already holds.
2. **Add an "active this year" flag and fix field consistency in the public station file.** In 2024, 2,841 of 10,700 listed stations had no volume records, and the discontinuation field cannot separate inactive stations from classification-only or weight-only sites. The 2025 file also changed the functional-code layout and dropped the rural/urban suffix. Its rural/urban area should be stated explicitly.
3. **Encourage a separate rural low-volume factor group.** In the TMAS instructions or the next TMG update, FHWA could recommend that states with substantial rural collector and local mileage keep a factor group for those roads, with at least six continuous stations. Where a state does not, it could report which factor group it applies to those roads.
4. **Release the nonmotorized station file.** FHWA could publish TMAS bicycle and pedestrian station locations, with their urban/rural field, and the number of jurisdictions submitting. This would let researchers and states see where rural nonmotorized counts are missing.
5. **Allow and encourage rural sites in coverage gaps.** FHWA could point states to counties and road classes with no continuous station, especially those with high rural death counts, when they add or relocate sites.

4. Conclusion

TMAS should be extended. Small changes to how its data are reported and published would show where rural roads are counted and where they are not. They would help states place stations where rural people are dying, at little or no added burden. The full analysis, data, and code are available at DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23772244.

Respectfully submitted,

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